

Site B, Student Interview 4

[0:00:00.0] **Interviewer:** We'll dive right in. Okay, so I know this was kind of a while back now, but do you remember at all like the lesson plan when [Site B Instructor] was talking about data analysis and how do you feel like the lessons about qualitative data analysis went for you?

Wei: Well, I'm a second year PhD student, so this is my [0:00:30.0] very first inquiry course. I chose to start from qualitative research because I'm, I don't have a really strong quantitative background, and [Site B Instructor] is very, very highly rated teacher like among my peers. And I've heard about her, but when I'm actually in the course, well this thing, a similar from what I heard is that she has a [0:01:00.0] really great teaching method and very very relax, and she's a very nice person, very flexible. And actually, because she had a really rich background, so she always has things to say from her own background. I think that's, that could be like really great example because if we read other researchers' studies, and we don't really always have like on-time [0:01:30.0] feedback from that particular researcher, but when she talks about her research, we can always just talk to her and see what she thought about it and what she thinks about it right now. What's different from what I thought is – because I know you're a PhD student – we (set) a lot in our research and we work on [0:02:00.0] references, but I heard in class she rarely. I don't think, I don't think she ever asked us to like reference, to have to keep like, for example, APA style, or make a reference list. Her assignment, so in the class, we basically just discuss, I think that's a really good method for students to reflect. Because qualitative research can [0:02:30.0] be very subjective, which is not a bad thing, but being subjective means like you, you should be like expressing your understanding or standing on your perspective and talking about stuff. So I think the discussion in classroom is really great. And we also have I think, three main projects among this whole semester during which we practiced observation and interview. And these [0:03:00.0] are two very widely used and strong methods to conduct qualitative research. So and she actually encouraged us to find some interesting topic, not necessarily something related to field, but it should be like really interesting. For example, I took my partner to rock climbing and we play cards and we both like observed each other. I think that's really important because [0:03:30.0] just for example, during observation you need to be like really into it and have an interest in it to kind of start to be perspective, and pay attention to that specific thing. I think that's a really good start for us to experience what is- how to get very detailed about things that we are focusing on. So yeah, for two, I [0:04:00.0] definitely love this course. And to, just to summarize, I think that in classroom discussions great and the off-class assignments are, because this is still intro level course, so that's the, the assignment really got us a very good first impression experience of how qualitative like research is not scary and it's not always very tired and we can enjoy it. [0:04:30.0] And yeah, I think that's the main part like the two parts of the course, and I really enjoyed it.

Interviewer: So you talked a little bit about you did in an observation and you had different like activities or assignments that you collected data, It sounds like. After you collected that data, and I know you shared a little bit about [0:05:00.0] this, but could you speak a little bit about what qualitative analytic approach or approaches you were being asked to kind of look at your data? With maybe like the lens that you were using to look at your data?

Wei: Yeah, sure. So although I mentioned she doesn't she never ask us to do like a very formal and serious reference [0:05:30.0] list or something. She, her courses, actually, she, her course actually had like heavier reading then the other course I have. But I think the reason is

that she wants to provide us was like methodology readings, and also some actual case studies to let us see how the methodologies are used in those studies. And the, and there is one more thing [0:06:00.0] I really like. The materials she provide us, as you mentioned, were principles we've been using. She always have this like cheat list that she'd summarize. She's, she kind of summarize the most important stuff in the method part of this week's reading. So, for the observation assignment she actually provide us a list, like what part should you pay [0:06:30.0] more attention to when you observe. For example, before I, before I read that list, I was thinking we mainly just describe what each, like the activity, like the steps of that activity and what I learned from that activity. But actually, in fact she also said, like 'you start the observation actually before you start that activity'. For example, (inaudible) cause that' [0:07:00.0] s kind of like being participatory observation, and so the observer being myself is one of the participant of the activity. So, at the very top of the list, I remember she said you start, you start the observation by observing the environment. For example, when you get out home and going to do the activity. What's the weather like? And how [0:07:30.0] do you feel? And what are people dressing as? And when you see your teammate, what he or she says and like very tiny maybe small specific facial experience and their gestures that always, that kind of sometimes because people are using different, because people have people are comfortable to express themselves using different ways. Some, some people they talk, some people they [0:08:00.0] think a little bit or talk with their hands using gestures, or they, or they barely, if they barely talk, then more information you should get from the are maybe, from their gestures and what they do. So she really like broadened my knowledge in this part of like, like you're doing observation or qualitative research, what kind of information can you get [0:08:30.0] and how can I get like, more like the most information from what you're doing? And yeah, to summarize, she basically have three kind of materials like theories, methodology readings, and some case studies. And she make a cheat sheet and PowerPoint for us to help us to refer to when we do the assignment. And yeah! So I think those really [0:09:00.0] equipped me was this new knowledge or that week's topic from different perspective. And yeah, that was, that was a great experience.

Interviewer: So I know in one of the lessons, you all did an activity, and I'd just what to share this – she's shared this with us – and I want to share my screen just to jog [0:09:30.0] your memory cause

Wei: yeah, sure.

Interviewer: In case you've forgot about it, but does this look kind of familiar to you? Do you remember [daughter] interviews segment?

Wei: Oh, yeah. This is from the last week or yeah. The coding one. I remember this, this is about this girl and her dad who got a disease and [0:10:00.0] how her family's helping him.

Interviewer: Do you just want to talk to me a little bit about how that entire activity went for you?

Wei: Okay. So that, yeah sure. So that week's topic is coding. And so she was she's [Site B Instructor] says she conducted this interview by herself a couple years ago. And this is one of the [0:10:30.0] interviews, like one small part of that interview. And that activity is that we are we teamed up, like we always do, like we always did. I was in a group of three. So we are we, we got one sheet of the real-wording material and the other sheet of like a table then she mentioned us we can started to. That table, I' [0:11:00.0] m sorry I don't I don't actually remember the details, but the rows are marked with the things that she, oh sorry the columns

are the things she said we can pay attention to like some theme where people's feelings within that paperwork. And the rows are marked by different paragraph, I think. For example, we're supposed to take [0:11:30.0] a take a note of like in paragraph one what theme do you think it is and what are the interviewees feeling about it, and you can take some other memos of it. So the method we were suggested to use is to find keywords.

Interviewer: Okay

Wei: So if I remember correctly, that interview was about like how, how [daughter] is the [0:12:00.0] interviewee, right? So how [daughter] perspective changed. [daughter] perspective of her father getting sick, how her perspective of that specific situation changed from worried to you know actually a more positive way, positive path. So our group, our group after reading that we so [Site B Instructor] started a classroom discussion. So each group, so like each group, will take turns to have [0:12:30.0] one group member summarize what they discussed. So, I remember what I said about our group is that on, so I think it would be really beneficial if the researcher already have a research question on their mind. That would be really beneficial for them to set a pre, like sorry, I don't remember that term. Like the codes they set before.

[0:13:00.0] I: Oh, like *a priori*?

Wei: Yeah like, like a pre-coding. I don't know that term, but something called that. So I like for example, if you're looking forward to, if you're looking for to answer a question of like those, those four Ws, like what, where, how, why, [daughter's] perspective changed, then regarding what you can find keywords about [0:13:30.0] the events and where it's like the locations at that event happened and why. It's more about [daughter's] different perspective and how she feels and how is like the reasons why she think that even change her perspective because there are other people involved, like what she thinks about her brothers and sisters, or involving like taking care of her [0:14:00.0] father. So yeah, actually, I think other groups all have different perspective as well. But I think the one more thing I like [Site B Instructor] material is that she, she managed to find that balance that we have enough freedom to express ourselves, but she's so sure, she was still able to keep us around that topic and around that framework. I think [0:14:30.0] that's one thing that qualitative teachers may think about. As like, as I mentioned, qualitative research can be really subjective. That means students all have freedoms being like the speaker of their own research. But also how can, you keep them follow that widely used method or how can you keep them in that framework? I think that's really important and [0:15:00.0] very crucial start point to think about how to teach this thing.

Interviewer: Yeah, yeah, that's something, kind of that structure almost, it's something that I think about a lot too, as I'm engaging with qual classes. I just want to quickly ask. So you briefly mentioned like 4 W's like what, where, why, when. Is that or was [0:15:30.0] that something that [Site B Instructor] asked you to maybe like pay attention to or was that just was that something that you, like your words?

Wei: Oh that was just my idea.

Interviewer: Oh that's okay, that's great. I was just clarifying.

Wei: I was, I got those I got that idea because I, I don't remember. I took those kinda like [0:16:00.0] that kind of writing, writing class and the teacher was like if you are trying to describe something, think about the 4 W's. Like when, who is there, where and how, yeah.

She She she she didn't really confine our ideas. She give suggestions and she gave us that table. If you'll have that in your hand, that could I [0:16:30.0] hope what I said and that will make sense to you and you know,

Interviewer: Yes It totally makes sense and it's that was very helpful. You earlier used the language coding to kind of talk out this lesson. And so, I think you said something like, "Oh, this class was about coding." How would you describe coding to a student who [0:17:00.0] had never heard of coding in qualitative research before?

Wei: That is a great question because before I took that course, and I consider myself a student and I heard coding from like the field of computer science, and how they like just coding. And, but like when I actually entered this field, I feel like a lot of social scientists they use [0:17:30.0] coding to do qualitative research and it's not only about like typing stuff. And so if I'm gonna, I'm gonna explain that to my future student, I'm going to start from a really general thing. Like coding is the process that helps you to get a clear impression about what data by categorizing, and looking and finding the essence [0:18:00.0] within them, like finding themes. Because what I learned from [Site B Instructor], from this course, that coding is basically, you categorize them first. you'll put the similar codes together to generate themes. That's a very basic method to deal with data in like content analysis and like topic analysis or like interaction analysis. So yeah, I think that word was widely used in [0:18:30.0] computer science and the field of technology, but for itself, it's really very simple and descriptive. Just a way to get closer to your data.

Interviewer: Mhm. So if you were going to kind of distinguish between the idea of coding and the idea of categorizing, do you think that there's any distinguishing points? how might you make sense of the [0:19:00.0] difference? it's okay if--

Wei: Oh yeah um you actually mention something that I was wondering. But I think, like in my mind because there's something called, there's codes, then coding and category or categories. And categorizing. Or what I'm thinking is, well, if I were talking about difference between codes and categories, I mean, I'm going to [0:19:30.0] say that the codes will be as I mentioned a keyword or the essence of what that piece of data means, but categories. Category is a general, is a more it's like you team data up. I'm not sure if I'm, I'm just speaking for myself, I'm just speaking for myself. So I think coding for example, you [0:20:00.0] have like this [daughter's] interview, each of the paragraph is talking about event, and the name of that event, for example, her father being sick, that could be a code. For categories, I will say that all those events belongs to one category instead of like 3, 4 codes. That's the way I'm thinking about it. And um I, from what [0:20:30.0] I've read, I think like maybe in the research field, coding the word coding is more widely used and it's more formal. And the categories is used to explain how you code. And it's not really, I mean I don't read a lot in this field, but I kind of feel like it's not that widely used in [0:21:00.0] formal research talking about data. That's just some differences-

Interviewer: That's awesome and you mentioned like coding as kind of like the essence of what the data is about. And I just thought that was so generative. And I had never thought about coding that way before and I definitely will be. So thank you for sharing that. So your instructor [0:21:30.0] so [Site B Instructor] invited you to watch a film. Do you remember the film that that you guys watched?

Wei: We watched like 2, 3 films. One is about ancient healing, herbal medicine one in a European village. And the other is about the Chinese (inaudible). Like which one would you like to discuss?

Interviewer: Yeah, I think that the first one. So in [0:22:00.0] that film did [Site B Instructor] ask you to kinda like pay attention to anything in particular? And how did, how did you think about, you know, well, viewing both of these films honestly, as related to learning about how to analyze qualitative data?

Wei: Sorry that film has actually more than a month ago. Well, I do remember she oh yeah. I think that [0:22:30.0] was I think I still got her powerpoint here. Like during that week. She showed us her PowerPoint first and that there was one slide. If you gave me, 20-second I'll be able to find it. I think that slide was about like different theories. I'm checking. Okay. She gave you a slide of things that we may pay attention to. Like, [0:23:00.0] what is the theoretical background, what are the, like what is the content regarding economics, politics, and the culture and history.

Interviewer: It's not a huge deal. So don't worry too much about it. And I'm noticing that we only have two more minutes left. And it's really important for me that I get to ask you at least [0:23:30.0] the last question. So our last question is, what suggestions might you have for an instructor teaching qualitative data analysis, like in the future. So if you were going to take a qualitative research class, and you were going to focus on just analyzing qualitative data, do you have any suggestions for how that might be taught to students or how you're [0:24:00.0] learning might be supported?

Wei: Okay yeah, sure. So I would say firstly, I will think about like the background of my students. If I'm teaching a PhD course, as I'm a PhD student, the most important thing for me is how can I make this how can I use this for my own research? Like practically, what kind of, what [0:24:30.0] kind of research topic can qualitative? Sorry, what kind of research question can Qualitative research methods answer for me. and for each if, if we are able to make a very general like trees style thing about like what each topics, what kind of topic is compatible for qualitative research. And regarding that, what kind of data should we collect? If I had [0:25:00.0] that kind of cheat sheet, then that would definitely like save the world. But I know, I know it's hard and it can, it should be flexibly, it should be kept flexible. And that's how research gets involved and developed. But just a really general start point for me to think about well how can I solve my own problem with qualitative [0:25:30.0] research. And although I mentioned that I really liked the flexibles style about [Site B Instructor] course, I will say if there's one thing I wanted to add to this course is that think about the connection to your own research. And maybe make a really rough and brief proposal of how the method you learned can be used to answer maybe one of [0:26:00.0] your, maybe one of your research questions. Well, like a sub-question. So when we start, cuz, cuz we both need to do our own research. And when we start to think about our own research, in our minds, there'll be a connection like linking us back to this course to what methods we've learned, and how did we think about this [0:26:30.0] methods can be applied? Yeah, that would be. I love, I love [Site B Instructor], and I loved this course. Just one more thing. I'm thinking very practically. I may, I would have liked to have yeah.

Interviewer: Yeah I hear you. So before I let you go, I just want to make sure is there anything else that you wanted to share with [0:27:00.0] me today about qualitative data analysis or anything that you learned and want to be on record before we go ahead and I we finish our weekends?

Wei: Yeah, actually, I think this is a really good start point. This course, this course is a really good start point. And I'm think about taking more courses. And I was like, if maybe [0:27:30.0] at the end of the course she can talk about like, what's your next step could be, because [[PERSONAL DETAILS ABOUT TWO PROFESSORS IN THE DEPARTMENT REDACTED]]. And I'm thinking about taking his course. But I'm also thinking cause the classroom students all have different background. I'm from the School of Education. [0:28:00.0] There are students from school of public policies or health. And like for my own field if I want to conduct my own research and I'm interested in this method How can I go further? Do you have any recommendation for future like other courses we would like to take? Or is there any software we can use to do this coding? [0:28:30.0] And this is always really nice and supportive. And I feel like she is basically okay about whatever we said. But I sometimes because I still email her my questions about research and she replies saying you can do this and you can do this, you can do this. And I just wanted you to back me up and tell me what do [0:29:00.0] you think the best way? Just let me know. Yeah, yeah. Basically, to summarize, I wanted to summarize about this course. Maybe at the very end two things, just a suggestion about how we can move forward to the future. And just maybe express that you can always ask me questions and the research topics when we talk about and how yeah, I [0:29:30.0] hope that makes sense,

Interviewer: You're making perfect sense. And if you in the future have any questions, I my email Inbox is open if you have questions about like potentially like taking call qual because I know that there's so many different kinds of classes. And I would be more than happy to like schedule, like email back and forth [0:30:00.0] then, you know, I don't, I forget what your research focuses, but but some suggestions about maybe some specific classes that I would maybe like fit. So please feel free to email me as a peer and friend.

Wei: Oh, thank you so much.

Interviewer: Sure. Thank you. Of course. I just yeah. Thank you so much again for your time today and [0:30:30.0] I hope that everything kind of settles down with the chaos. That sounds so stressful. So I'm just like sending good energy if on.

Wei: Thank you so much. Great. Okey-dokey,

Interviewer: We'll have a good day and thanks again.

Wei: Thank you. Bye.